

When Gandhi first proposed the salt march to Dandi, he had not intended for women to participate. Along with Sarojini Naidu, Chattopadhyay convinced him otherwise. She herself was among a small group that marched to Chowpatty beach in Bombay and made salt there.

Looking to the future

After 1947, Chattopadhyay threw herself into several tasks, including the rehabilitation of Partition refugees. But arguably her most important contribution was her role in encouraging the production and preservation of Indian handicrafts and handloom goods. Many traditional crafts had been replaced by factory goods during colonial rule, with craftsmen suffering as a result. Appointed Chairman of the All India Handicrafts and Handloom Board, she enlisted talented professionals to create channels for the production, marketing and sale of handcrafted products. She travelled extensively to survey the state of these communities and their art, and oversaw the setting up of schools, institutions and design centres that would preserve and promote traditional techniques. Her interest in reviving traditional crafts extended beyond India; it was through her efforts that the World Crafts Council, an organization affiliated to UNESCO, came into being.